

Morning Edition

Monday, 24 August 2026

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Seychelles launches its natural capital economy, without you in the room yet

01

This is the exact national planning process HARMONiSE was designed to feed into, and it launched three days ago in Victoria without a technical partners list attached yet.

STORY NOTES

On 21 August, Seychelles' government and UNDP held the inception workshop for "Enabling the Transition to a Blue and Green

Economy," bringing together government institutions, development partners, civil society, academia, private sector representatives and community stakeholders. The stated aim: put biodiversity, ecosystem services and natural capital at the centre of national development planning, not as an environmental add-on.

You have spent years arguing that Seychelles needs spatial data infrastructure that sits inside government planning rather than beside it. A national accounting exercise built around natural capital is the first policy vehicle in years that could actually require that infrastructure to exist. No technical working group list has been published yet, which means the door on who shapes the data architecture is still open.

Track the Ministry of Fisheries, Agriculture and Blue Economy's channels for the technical working group nominations; that is where a SHORE seat gets decided.

undp.org/mauritius-seychelles

STORY ARTICLE

Three days ago, in a conference room, Seychelles committed itself, on paper, to running its national development planning through a natural capital lens. UNDP and the Ministry of Fisheries, Agriculture and Blue Economy convened

government institutions, development partners, academia, civil society and private sector representatives at an inception workshop for "Enabling the Transition to a Blue and Green Economy." The framing is deliberately ambitious: biodiversity and ecosystem services move from footnote to input variable in how the country plans growth.

You have written before about the gap between Seychelles' policy ambition and its data infrastructure. The country has a sovereign blue bond, a marine spatial plan covering 30% of its EEZ, and a reputation as a blue economy pioneer. What it has not had is a systematic way to price what its ocean actually holds, at the resolution a natural capital account requires. Ecosystem service valuation, seafloor extent, habitat condition and carbon stock estimates all need spatial data as their foundation, not as an afterthought bolted on once the economics are decided.

This is where the project intersects with HARMONiSE. The framework was built on the premise that hydrospatial data has to be structured for policy use from the outset, not translated into policy language after the fact by whoever happens to be in the room. A national natural capital accounting exercise either builds that structure in, or reproduces the same fragmented, donor-

shaped data landscape Seychelles has lived with for a decade.

The obvious objection: inception workshops are where good intentions go to become slide decks. Seychelles has run blue economy strategy documents before, and the country's institutional capacity to absorb another cross-sectoral planning exercise is not infinite. That is a fair read of the base rate. But two things differ here. First, UNDP is structuring this as an implementation project with named technical outputs, not a strategy paper. Second, no technical working group composition has been announced yet, which means the mandate for who does the spatial data work is still undecided.

That is the actionable window. If the natural capital accounting methodology gets built by a consultancy parachuted in for six months, it will look like every other framework document sitting in a ministry drawer. If it gets built with Seychellois technical capacity, including SHORE, embedded from the start, it has a chance of surviving past the funding cycle.

The High-Income SIDS Paradox sits directly underneath this story too. Seychelles is priced out of concessional climate finance by its GNI per capita, while carrying the same physical exposure and thin technical bench as any other small island state. A national accounting framework that

demonstrates the actual value and vulnerability of its natural capital, rigorously, is one of the few tools that could shift how multilateral finance treats a country in Seychelles' income bracket. That argument only works if the underlying data can withstand scrutiny.

What happens next is unglamorous: technical working groups, terms of reference, a data inventory. Worth watching closely anyway, because this is the first time in years a live government process has needed exactly the infrastructure SHORE has been building a case for.

undp.org/mauritius-seychelles

02

**A U.S. seabed
mining application
just cleared a
procedural gate
the ISA never got
to set**

A U.S. company just cleared a procedural threshold toward becoming the first entity issued a commercial deep seabed mining permit outside ISA jurisdiction, and that precedent will shape how BBNJ's environmental impact assessment provisions get tested.

STORY NOTES

On 19 August, NOAA determined that The Metals Company USA's consolidated application for an exploration license and commercial recovery permit in the Clarion-Clipperton Zone meets the information threshold required under the Deep Seabed Hard Mineral Resources Act. That opens a 60-day public comment period, closing 19 October, with a virtual public hearing on 13 October.

This is the first application of its kind to reach this stage under U.S. domestic law rather than through the International Seabed Authority, the body every other seabed mining application has gone through. NOAA still has to evaluate TMC USA's financial and technical capacity and prepare an environmental impact statement before any permit is issued, so this is a procedural gate, not an approval.

If you want to weigh in, or want to know who else is, the comment period is public.

[federalregister.gov/documents/2026/08/19](https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2026/08/19)

On 19 August, the U.S. National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration ruled that The Metals Company's American subsidiary had filed a complete application: an exploration licence and a commercial recovery permit, both covering nickel, cobalt and manganese nodules in the Clarion-Clipperton Zone between Hawaii and Mexico. The company filed six months earlier, in February. NOAA has now opened a 60-day public comment period, running to 19 October, with a hearing scheduled for 13 October.

Nothing about this is an approval. NOAA still has to assess TMC USA's financial responsibility, its technological capability and the adequacy of its recovery plan, then produce an environmental impact statement. That is months, plausibly years, of process left. But the procedural step that just happened matters more than its modesty suggests: this is the first deep seabed mining application in U.S. history to be filed and processed entirely outside the International Seabed Authority's jurisdiction, using a 1980 domestic law that predates U.S. engagement with UNCLOS.

Every seabed mining application before this one went through the ISA, however contested and slow that process has been. TMC's pivot to U.S. domestic licensing was

explicitly a bet that Washington's regulatory track would move faster than Kingston's multilateral one. NOAA advancing this application in six months, against an ISA process that has taken the better part of a decade to produce a draft mining code, suggests that bet is paying off.

This matters to BBNJ implementation in a way that is easy to miss because the two regimes are jurisdictionally separate. BBNJ governs biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction; seabed minerals fall under UNCLOS Part XI and the ISA. But BBNJ's environmental impact assessment provisions were negotiated on the assumption that activities in the high seas, including extractive ones, would eventually need to run through a common environmental standard. A precedent where a major seabed mining operation proceeds under unilateral domestic law, with its own environmental review track, tests whether that assumption holds or whether states simply forum-shop toward whichever process moves fastest.

The counterargument, which the U.S. and TMC would both make, is that domestic licensing under DSHMRA is lawful and long-established, and that criticism of the pathway is really criticism of the ISA's slowness dressed up as a jurisdictional objection. That is not unreasonable. The ISA's mining code negotiations have missed

multiple self-imposed deadlines, and states with seabed mining ambitions have legitimate grounds for frustration.

What is worth tracking from Victoria is not the mining question itself but the precedent question: does a state acting unilaterally on the high seas, backed by domestic legislation, get treated as a going concern once it happens, however contested its legal basis? BBNJ's High Ambition Coalition, which Seychelles co-chairs with Palau, has staked its credibility on multilateral environmental review being the standard that holds. This application is the first real test of whether that standard can compete with a faster unilateral track.

[federalregister.gov/documents/2026/08/19](https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2026/08/19)

03

**The GEBCO grid moved.
Here is the number for
your next funding pitch.**

28.7%

of the global ocean
floor now has
direct-
measurement
bathymetric

coverage — up
from 27.3% a year
ago

The number you quote in every Seabed 2030 slide just moved, and the 1.4-point jump this year is the kind of concrete figure your funding pitches keep missing.

STORY NOTES

GEBCO released its 2026 grid this year, taking global seafloor mapping coverage from 27.3% to 28.7%, roughly 104 million square kilometres, an area larger than twice the Earth's land surface. Almost five million square kilometres of new bathymetric data were added over the past twelve months.

The pace matters more than the headline. At roughly 1.4 percentage points a year, full seafloor coverage by the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 project's 2030 target is arithmetically out of reach unless the annual contribution rate accelerates sharply. The gap is concentrated in the Indian Ocean and South Pacific, precisely the regions where Seychelles and its Indo-Pacific SIDS peers sit.

gebco.net/news/release-gebco2026-grid

STORY ARTICLE

Twenty-eight point seven percent. That is how much of the world's ocean floor

now has direct-measurement bathymetric coverage, according to the 2026 release of the GEBCO grid, up from 27.3% in the 2025 release. In absolute terms, the increase represents just under five million square kilometres of newly mapped seafloor added in a single year, bringing the total mapped area to roughly 104 million square kilometres.

Put the number in a room and it sounds impressive. Put it against the 2030 target and it is not. The Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 project set out to map the entire ocean floor, all 361 million square kilometres of it, by the end of the decade. At the current rate of roughly 1.4 percentage points a year, reaching 100% by 2030 would require the annual contribution rate to more than double from here, and to do so consistently for four straight years. That has not happened yet in the project's history.

The unevenness matters as much as the aggregate. Coverage in the North Atlantic and around well-resourced coastal states is dense. Coverage in the Indian Ocean and the South Pacific, where hydrographic capacity is thin and survey vessels are scarce, lags well behind. That is not an accident of geography. It is a direct function of which countries have the fleets, the training pipelines and the crowdsourced bathymetry infrastructure to contribute data, and which do not.

This is the gap HARMONiSE was built to address, and it is also the gap that makes the 2030 target credible or not depending on whether anyone closes it. A global percentage that averages over a fully-mapped North Atlantic and a nearly-empty western Indian Ocean tells you nothing about whether Seychelles, or any Indo-Pacific SIDS, has the seafloor data it needs to plan a marine protected area, site a submarine cable, or model a tsunami risk zone. The number that matters to you is not 28.7%, it is whatever the coverage figure is for the Seychelles EEZ specifically, and that figure is not the one GEBCO publishes on its homepage.

There is a funding argument buried in this. You have been told, correctly, that your pitches need harder numbers. This is one: a documented four-year window in which the global mapping rate needs to more than double, and a documented regional shortfall concentrated in exactly the geography SHORE operates in. That is a more precise ask than "the ocean floor is unmapped." It is a specific capacity gap, in a specific ocean basin, with a specific project already measuring it annually. Anyone funding hydrospatial capacity building in the western Indian Ocean now has a public, citable baseline to fund against.

gebco.net/news/release-gebco2026-grid

Kuala Lumpur, October. The Indo- Pacific room built for exactly your skill set.

Registration for the one Indo-Pacific hydrography meeting built for exactly your data-sprint skill set opened this week, and Kuala Lumpur in October is a realistic trip.

STORY NOTES

Registration is open for the Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting & Data Sprint, running 20–22 October 2026 in Kuala Lumpur. It brings together hydrographic offices, academic institutions, research organisations, industry and government agencies from across the Indo-Pacific to coordinate ocean mapping work, with a dedicated data sprint session for hands-on GEBCO Grid contribution.

This is the room where the western Indian Ocean's mapping gap, the one sitting underneath today's GEBCO release, actually gets worked on by the people doing the surveys and the crowdsourced bathymetry

submissions. Seychelles has no confirmed delegation yet.

gebco.net/news/registration-open-seabed-2030-indo-pacific-mapping-meeting-2026

STORY ARTICLE

Registration opened this week for the Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting & Data Sprint, set for 20–22 October in Kuala Lumpur. The agenda pairs a standard coordination meeting, hydrographic offices, universities, industry and government agencies comparing notes on regional mapping progress, with a working data sprint: participants sit down and actually process bathymetric data into the GEBCO Grid over the course of the event.

This is not a conference in the ordinary sense. It is closer to a working session with a name-badge lanyard attached. The previous Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting, held in early 2025, produced concrete coordination outcomes on crowdsourced bathymetry submission pipelines from small Pacific states with no dedicated hydrographic fleet. The Indo-Pacific framing this year explicitly widens that remit toward the western Indian Ocean, which is where Seychelles sits and where, as this morning's GEBCO figures show, coverage still lags.

Three days in Kuala Lumpur is a genuinely reasonable trip from Victoria, and the substantive case for going is stronger than the logistical one. SHORE's entire premise is that the region needs data infrastructure built and owned locally rather than imported episodically by whichever donor is funding a survey that year. A room full of the people who actually run crowdsourced bathymetry programmes for small island states is where that argument gets tested against practitioners, not policymakers. It is also where partnerships get formed before, not after, the next funding cycle opens.

The honest counterpoint: attending a mapping meeting does not, by itself, close a data gap. Seychelles has sent delegations to technical meetings before without a durable change in national bathymetric survey capacity following. What would make this one different is showing up with something concrete to contribute or request, a specific crowdsourced bathymetry dataset, a specific training gap, a specific ask of Seabed 2030's regional partners, rather than attending as an observer.

No Seychelles delegation has been confirmed yet, which means the seat is still open. If SHORE is going to make the case for a national hydrospatial mandate, a technical meeting three months out, in a city a nine-hour flight away, with registration

open right now, is as concrete a first move as this space offers.

gebco.net/news/registration-open-seabed-2030-indo-pacific-mapping-meeting-2026

\$ story --id=05

⚡ FUNDING WINDOW

Commonwealth Blue Charter Incubator reopens mid-2026 – Seychelles has already won this one twice

The grant window Seychelles has already won from twice is reopening mid-year, and this time the ask should come from SHORE, not just the ministry.

STORY NOTES

The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator's next call for proposals opens mid-2026, offering grants up to £50,000 for government-led partnerships with NGOs or private sector entities. Priority areas: marine pollution, ecosystem restoration, sustainable blue economy, sustainable fisheries, ocean-climate work.

Seychelles was one of eight projects funded in the previous round, alongside Barbados, Canada, Fiji, Kiribati, Nigeria and Sri Lanka. The structure requires government

leadership, so any SHORE-led proposal needs a government partner locked in before the call opens, not after.

No fixed deadline published yet.

thecommonwealth.org/bluecharter/project-incubator

STORY ARTICLE

The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator is reopening its call for proposals in the middle of this year, with grants of up to £50,000 available for early-stage, catalytic ocean projects. The structure requires a government-led partnership, meaning a Commonwealth country's government has to be the applicant, working with NGO or private sector partners to deliver.

Seychelles has form here. In the previous funding round, eight projects were selected across Barbados, Canada, Fiji, Kiribati, Nigeria, Seychelles and two in Sri Lanka, meaning Seychelles' government has already demonstrated it can clear this bar. That track record is worth more than it looks: a funder that has already said yes once is a materially easier ask the second time, and the relationship with the Commonwealth Blue Charter secretariat should already exist inside government.

The priority areas this round, marine pollution, ecosystem restoration, sustainable blue economy, sustainable

fisheries and the ocean-climate nexus, all sit close enough to SHORE's hydrospatial mandate that a proposal is not a stretch. A grant in this bracket will not fund a full survey programme, but £50,000 is a realistic amount to pilot a specific, bounded piece of hydrospatial infrastructure work, a crowdsourced bathymetry training pipeline, a coastal habitat baseline for the marine spatial plan, something with a clear before-and-after that a government partner can point to when the next, larger funding conversation happens.

The catch is structural, not financial. This incubator does not accept applications directly from NGOs or research institutes; it funds governments, who then work with partners. That means the actual task here is not writing a proposal, it is securing a government co-applicant, most plausibly the Ministry of Fisheries, Agriculture and Blue Economy, given it is already running the natural capital accounting project covered above, before the call formally opens. Waiting until the call is live to start that conversation costs weeks that are better spent scoping the pitch.

No specific deadline has been published for the mid-2026 call yet. The Commonwealth Blue Charter secretariat has said further detail will follow, and the only reliable move now is watching the page directly rather than waiting for a press release to land in an inbox.

thecommonwealth.org/bluecharter/project-incubator

A \$200,000 grant ceiling, built for the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, sidesteps the income trap entirely

This is a five-year, five-million-dollar fund built specifically for the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, Seychelles among them, and grants up to \$200,000 are large enough to fund an actual hydrospatial programme, not a pilot.

STORY NOTES

The Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency have opened a joint fund for Commonwealth SIDS: US\$5 million over five years, with individual grants of up to US\$200,000 available to governments of the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, Seychelles among them, for projects on climate resilience,

STORY ARTICLE

A joint fund from the Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency is now open to governments of the 25 Commonwealth Small Island Developing States, Seychelles included, with individual project grants of up to US\$200,000. The fund totals US\$5 million across

ocean health and sustainable energy.

The Commonwealth has said full call-for-proposals detail will follow "in due course," meaning the eligibility and amount are confirmed but the application mechanics are not yet public. This is a fund to have a scoped proposal ready for, not one to wait on passively.

thecommonwealth.org/news/cop29-commonwealth-sids-fund

five years and is scoped to climate resilience, ocean health and sustainable energy, three categories broad enough to cover almost anything SHORE would plausibly propose.

The amount is the detail worth sitting with. Most ocean-focused SIDS funding mechanisms cap out in the tens of thousands, enough for a workshop, a training course, a pilot dataset. Two hundred thousand dollars is enough to fund an actual multi-year programme: a sustained bathymetric survey campaign, a data infrastructure build, a training pipeline that runs long enough to produce qualified people rather than a single workshop's worth of attendees.

The catch is that the mechanics are not public yet. The Commonwealth's own language is that "further information about the call for proposals will be published on Commonwealth in due course," which means eligibility and amount are confirmed, application process and

deadline are not. That is awkward for planning, but not unusual for a fund at this stage of its life.

The strategic move is not to wait for the call to open before starting to write. A proposal built around hydrospatial data infrastructure, positioned honestly against ocean health rather than stretched to fit climate resilience or energy where it does not naturally sit, can be drafted and refined now, so that when the mechanics publish, the response time is measured in days rather than weeks.

There is a positioning argument specific to Seychelles too. The country sits awkwardly inside "SIDS" as a category because of its income level, the recurring frustration behind the High-Income SIDS Paradox. This fund does not distinguish by income within the Commonwealth SIDS list; eligibility is membership, not GNI per capita. That is one of the few funding mechanisms where the paradox does not apply, and it is worth using while it is available.

FILE NO. 07

BBNJ COP1 is fixed for January. Five months to decide what the High Ambition Coalition actually fights for.

The date is now fixed for the meeting where the High Ambition Coalition Seychelles co-hosts with Palau either gets its unresolved PrepCom3 issues locked in or watches them get diluted.

STORY NOTES

BBNJ's first Conference of the Parties (COP1) is scheduled for 11–22 January 2027, following the conclusion of the third Preparatory Commission session in April 2026. PrepCom3 made progress on institutional and procedural groundwork but left a number of substantive issues, including elements of the environmental impact assessment regime, unresolved for states to fight over at COP1.

Seychelles co-hosts the BBNJ High Ambition Coalition with Palau, the bloc

pushing for the most protective reading of the treaty's implementation rules. With five months until COP1, this is the window for coalition-building and technical position papers, not the one to spend on anything else.

sdg.iisd.org/news/bbnj-agreement-cop1

STORY ARTICLE

The first Conference of the Parties to the BBNJ Agreement now has a fixed date: 11–22 January 2027. That closes out a year of preparatory work that began with the treaty's entry into force in January 2026 and ran through three sessions of the Preparatory Commission, the third of which wrapped in early April with what observers are calling, generously, mixed progress.

PrepCom3 delivered a report with recommendations and draft institutional elements for COP1 to formally adopt, covering things like the structure of the Scientific and Technical Body and initial financial rules. What it did not deliver was consensus on several of the provisions that determine how much teeth the treaty actually has, including parts of the environmental impact assessment framework, the mechanism most directly relevant to the deep seabed mining application under review at NOAA right now. Countries reserved positions rather than

resolving them, which is diplomatic language for kicking the fight to January.

This is where the BBNJ High Ambition Coalition matters, and where Seychelles' role in it stops being ceremonial. Co-hosted with Palau, the coalition exists specifically to hold the line on the treaty's most protective readings against states that would prefer a lighter-touch implementation. Every unresolved issue from PrepCom3 is now a live negotiating item for COP1, and five months is not a long runway to build coalition positions, secure co-sponsors and draft the technical language that turns "we want strong EIA rules" into text a plenary session can actually adopt.

The objection worth naming directly: high seas treaty negotiations move slowly by design, and one Preparatory Commission session leaving issues unresolved is normal, not alarming. States reserve positions at every multilateral negotiation until the room forces a decision. That is true, and it is also not a reason to treat the next five months as slack time. The states that arrive at COP1 with drafted text and secured co-sponsors get the agenda-setting advantage; the states that arrive with a general position and no text get negotiated around.

For Seychelles specifically, the stakes compound with the deep seabed mining story above. If a major seabed mining application proceeds through a domestic

U.S. process rather than the ISA, and COP1 is simultaneously deciding how rigorous BBNJ's own EIA standard will be for high seas activity, the two processes are effectively negotiating against each other over which environmental review standard becomes the reference point states cite. A coalition that shows up to COP1 without a settled, well-drafted EIA position cedes that reference point by default.

Five months is short for treaty diplomacy and long enough to matter. What Seychelles' negotiators, and the coalition secretariat, do with it now is largely invisible from the outside, which is exactly why it is worth tracking closely rather than waiting for the January headlines.

sdg.iisd.org/news/bbnj-agreement-cop1

Source: IISD SDG Knowledge Hub, PrepCom3 summary report, IDDRI policy brief on BBNJ PrepCom3.

08

STORY SPOTLIGHT

"Unlocking Sustainable Finance for the Green & Blue Economy: Governance, Resilience, and Investment Pathways"

— the theme of a Pacific SIDS dialogue Seychelles never heard about.

Sixty people just spent two days in Samoa building exactly the blue-and-green finance governance model your High-Income SIDS Paradox argument needs a comparison case for.

STORY NOTES

A two-day policy dialogue in Apia, Samoa brought together more than 60 participants under that theme, working through practical pathways to mobilise sustainable finance for Pacific SIDS.

Pacific SIDS and Indian Ocean SIDS rarely compare governance models directly, despite facing near-identical structural finance problems. Samoa's dialogue output, once published, is a direct comparison case for how a Pacific SIDS is structuring blue and green finance governance against how Seychelles is doing it through its own current process.

undp.org/samoa/press-releases

STORY ARTICLE

Apia hosted a two-day policy dialogue this week, more than 60 participants from government, development partners and civil society, working through what the organisers called "practical

pathways to mobilize sustainable finance" for the Pacific region's transition to a blue and green economy. The stated aim was governance design, not just financing volume: how do small island governments structure the institutions and rules that let blue and green finance actually flow, rather than sit in pledge documents.

This deserves attention for a reason that has nothing to do with the Pacific specifically. Indian Ocean SIDS and Pacific SIDS almost never compare governance approaches directly, despite carrying nearly identical structural problems: thin technical capacity, small absorptive capacity for large grants, and finance mechanisms designed around continental-scale economies that do not map cleanly onto an island state's institutions. Seychelles has more in common, structurally, with Samoa or Fiji than it does with most of its African Union blue economy peers, and yet the dialogue between these two blocs is thin.

Samoa's dialogue theme, governance, resilience and investment pathways treated as three linked components rather than three separate agenda items, is worth comparing directly against the design choices Seychelles is making right now in its own blue and green economy project, covered above. Both processes are trying to solve the same underlying problem: how a

small state builds financing governance sophisticated enough to satisfy investors and multilateral funders, without importing an institutional architecture sized for a much larger economy.

The honest caveat is that policy dialogues produce communiqués more often than they produce durable institutional change, and a two-day gathering in Apia is not, by itself, evidence that Pacific SIDS have solved a problem Seychelles has not. What it does produce, once the outputs are published, is a documented governance model built by a genuine peer, tested against a comparable set of constraints, that Seychelles' own natural capital accounting process could draw from directly rather than reinventing.

That comparison is also a Shorelines piece waiting to be written: a Pacific SIDS and an Indian Ocean SIDS, working the same problem in parallel with almost no cross-reference to each other, is exactly the kind of structural gap in the SIDS policy conversation that gets talked about in the abstract and rarely documented with two live, concurrent case studies.

undp.org/samoa/press-releases

A \$100 Million Fund Routes Around the SIDS Income Trap

Blended finance vehicle for SIDS blue economy reaches first close

A hundred-million-dollar blended finance vehicle built for SIDS blue economy investment just reached its first close, and blended finance is precisely the mechanism Seychelles needs to route around the High-Income SIDS Paradox.

STORY NOTES

A blended finance vehicle targeting \$100 million for blue economy investment in SIDS has reached its first close, combining public and private capital on concessional terms to fund projects that pure grant financing or pure commercial capital could not support alone.

Blended structures matter specifically for a state like Seychelles because eligibility usually runs on project bankability and blue economy sector fit, not on the GNI-per-capita thresholds that exclude Seychelles from most grant-based concessional finance. Worth tracking by name once its full structure, including whether it is deploying yet or still raising, is published.

carbon-pulse.com/536518

STORY ARTICLE

A blended finance vehicle aimed at raising \$100 million for blue economy investment across	Small Island Developing States has reached its first close. Blended finance combines
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concessional public capital, usually from development finance institutions or philanthropic sources, with commercial private investment, using the concessional layer to absorb enough risk that private capital is willing to come in behind it on terms it would not accept alone.

The mechanism matters more than the headline number for a country in Seychelles' position. Most grant-based concessional climate finance runs on income thresholds, and Seychelles' GNI per capita routinely prices it out of exactly the pools of money its physical vulnerability would

otherwise justify. Blended finance vehicles generally do not screen on national income at all; they screen on project bankability and sector fit. A fund built to invest in blue economy projects across SIDS, structured this way, is one of the few finance categories where Seychelles' income classification is simply irrelevant to eligibility.

That is the theoretical case. The practical one depends entirely on details not yet public: what counts as an eligible blue economy project, what ticket sizes the fund is targeting, whether it invests directly or through intermediaries, and crucially whether it is now deploying

capital or still in a raising phase. A first close is a fundraising milestone, not a deployment announcement. The fund could be a year away from writing its first cheque.

Still, worth flagging now rather than once the details are public, because blended finance vehicles of this kind typically build their pipeline of investable projects well before capital is fully raised. If SHORE, or a Seychelles-based blue economy venture, wants to be in the room when this fund is scoping its first cohort of investments, the conversation needs to start during the raising phase, not after the fund has already committed

its first tranche to projects sourced elsewhere.

The broader pattern is worth naming for Shorelines: 2026 has produced at least three distinct finance mechanisms this year alone, a Commonwealth incubator grant, a bilateral SIDS climate fund, and now a blended finance vehicle, all explicitly targeting blue economy investment in small island states, each with a different eligibility logic. That proliferation is itself a story: SIDS blue finance is fragmenting into parallel tracks faster than any single country's capacity to track and apply to all of them.

A pilot programme is deciding who owns SIDS ocean data, right now, while the design is still open

This is a UN Ocean Decade pilot built to fix the exact science-to-policy pipeline problem you have spent your career naming, and it is looking for SIDS practitioners to shape it before it hardens into its final design.

STORY NOTES

The UN Ocean Decade's SIDS Ocean Science Policy Network is running as a pilot project, aimed at building durable connective tissue between ocean science produced in and about small island states and the policy processes meant to use it. This is the pipeline problem named repeatedly in Shorelines: research gets produced, often about SIDS rather than with them, and rarely reaches the desk of the official who needs it in a usable form.

Because it is a pilot, its design is not fixed. Pilot phase is when structural choices, who

counts as a "policy user," what format research has to take to qualify as network output, are still being made rather than defended after the fact.

oceandecade.org/actions/sids-ocean-science-policy-network

STORY ARTICLE

The UN Ocean Decade is running a pilot project called the SIDS Ocean Science Policy Network, built to address a problem that has a name in this newsletter already: ocean science gets produced about small island states in enormous volume, and very little of it is structured to reach the policy desk that could actually use it. Papers get published, cited a handful of times, and never translated into a form a fisheries ministry or a marine spatial planning unit can act on within a budget cycle.

This is not a new observation. Every SIDS ocean governance conference for the past decade has had a panel on the science-to-policy gap. What makes this pilot worth attention is not the diagnosis, which everyone in the room already agrees on, but the fact that it is a pilot: the network's structure, who counts as a policy user, what format qualifies as network output, how SIDS researchers are credited and compensated for contributing, is still being

decided rather than already fixed and merely being rolled out.

That distinction matters because most science-to-policy initiatives in this space are designed by institutions based in the countries that produce the research, then offered to SIDS as a finished product to opt into. A pilot phase is the rare moment where the design decisions are still open to the people the network is meant to serve, rather than closed before SIDS practitioners are consulted at all.

There is a data sovereignty question sitting directly underneath this, and it is the one worth pushing hardest during the pilot phase specifically. Who owns the underlying data once it moves through the network. Whether SIDS-based researchers get named as authors and co-investigators, or whether their local knowledge gets extracted and republished under an institution based somewhere else entirely. Every past iteration of a science-to-policy platform in this region has answered that question by default, usually in favour of whoever wrote the grant proposal that funded the platform. A pilot is the point where that default can still be argued with.

The realistic path in is not a formal application, since pilots of this kind typically build their initial cohort through direct outreach and existing Ocean Decade contacts rather than an open call. That

makes the actionable step here relationship-building rather than form-filling: identifying who is running the pilot, and getting SHORE's name and the data sovereignty argument in front of them before the network's design decisions calcify into something the next SIDS delegation is simply asked to sign onto.

oceandecade.org/actions/sids-ocean-science-policy-network

Shorelines

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